Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Robinson Jeffers's "Hurt Hawks"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the speaker's admitted misanthropy in Robinson Jeffers's "Hurt Hawks" as it contrasts with his admiration for, variously, the beauty and strength of nature, both exhibited in the plight of the hurt hawks he has encountered include

alliteration,
ambiguity,
apostrophe,
confession,
contrast,
diction,
doppelgänger,
enjambment,
epithet,
imagery,
kenning,
liminality,
metaphor,
simile,
speaker,
symbol,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant, having spent quite a bit of time with Brontë's Lockwood and Heathcliff, will be very familiar with the concept misanthropy.

The young writer should recognize in the speaker's declaratively confessional" I'd sooner, except the penalties, kill a man than a hawk" (line 18) and his arrogantly deprecating apostrophe, "you communal people" (line 15), that the speaker sets himself apart from everyone who cannot, to the degree that he does, recognize nobility in nature, especially the communal people's inability to recognize or even remember the "wild God of the world" (line 13).

The speaker's "except the penalties" (line 18) might be recognized as aurally ambiguous [perhaps it is an intended pun (accept/except the penalties)] and thus as a reinforcement of the speaker's purposeful separation from the community of man.

The tone with which the speaker addresses the elements of nature differs from the tone with which he addresses his membership in the human race.

The speaker's paean to the injured raptor(s) speaks to both the strength and the beauty informing the descriptions of the dying hawk(s). Any organized discussion that reflects an understanding of the diction and imagery characterizing the speaker's tribute to the dying predator(s) serves to answer the prompt.

N.B.: Do not discount a student's argument, however it might arise, that the speaker in the poem sees in the hawk(s), the speaker himself by way of "the wild God of the world": the "intemperate and savage" injured hawk (line 16) and the "men who are dying" (line 17) remember the wild God of the world. Somewhere in the equation stands a misanthrope in contrast to "communal people."